Corollary 1: However, Note 0 does not mean that you can perpetually postpone learning anything new in programming languages. That would just leave you with a failing grade in college and no job prospects ever.

Corollary 2: Hopefully, what you learnt about Language 'X' would speed up your learning of Language 'Y'. At this point, it is not clear whether this is actually true, or just a myth in the software developer universe. At least, you can console yourself that learning Language 'X' enabled you to appreciate and understand Language 'Y' better.

Note 1: No software developer curriculum can be complete and sound.

The very fact that a curriculum has been designed and implemented for a novice programmer, and has been followed by 'wannabe' software developers implies that much of the course material has become outdated by the existence of Note 0.

Note 2: The existence of Note 1 does not preclude the existence of certain essential topics in every developer's curriculum.

Note 2 has been a maxim that all our college professors tried to instil in us. They just called it, "Getting your fundamentals right." The fundamentals for computer science are typically discrete mathematics, data structures, algorithms, operating systems and computer architecture. Every software developer curriculum tries to give a bird's-eye view of these wide and complex topics, and mostly succeeds in making students hate these topics.

Note 3: Curiosity never killed the software developer.

The most important quality for a successful software developer, certainly never mentioned in any software developer curriculum, is CURIOSITY. While it may have been fatal to the cat, it is necessary for a software developer to always remain curious. After all, it may help you find a lurking bug in your code, detect a Trojan horse, or spot the next Big Thing in Technology.

Note 4: Connections count!

As in any other human industry, your network matters; not just the Ethernet or Wi-Fi, but the one you establish with other software developers. Most of your professional learning comes from what you can pick up from another software developer, rather than from what you get out of a text book. 'Wannabe' software developers need to know and internalise the concept of 'six degrees of separation', which refers to the idea that a chain of statements about being a friend of a friend can be made to connect any two people, on an average in six steps or fewer. Your online connections, such as those on LinkedIn, would in most cases be the best bet for your introduction to a new job or new technology.

Note 5: No one in the software industry knows the Next Big Thing.

While Note 5 sounds highly pessimistic, there is comfort in the fact that it is universally true for everyone in the software industry. Therefore, your home-grown invention in software stands an equal chance of becoming the next Facebook, as the multi-million dollar effort from a major MNC. Therefore spend your spare time (provided you get some) on your pet software project. And if anyone in your family objects to your maniacal tendency to stay online, tell them that you are destined to make the College DropOut Billionaires list alongside Mark Zuckerberg, Bill Gates, and of course, the legendary Steve Jobs.

Note 6: The Missing Manual Notes for Software Developers are always evolving!

So no one knows how big the Missing Manual is, since it is obviously missing! This is a big comfort, because whether you know less or more of it does not really matter in the long run.

My 'must-read book' for this month

This month's must-read book suggestion comes from me. In keeping with the non-technical nature of this month's column, I wanted to highlight a favourite of mine, 'The Hitch-Hiker's Guide to the Galaxy' by Douglas Adams. While the plot is nonsensical, it lends itself to imagination. Some of the qualities that we need as software developers are qualities brought forth in the book: unceasing curiosity, the ability to cope (or pretend to cope) with change, and an inherent ability to laugh at one's own foolishness, always.

If you have a favourite programming book or article that you think is a must-read for every programmer, please do send me a note with the book's name, and a short write-up on why you think it is useful, so I can mention it in this column. It would help many readers who want to improve their coding skills.

If you have any favourite programming puzzles that you would like to discuss on this forum, please send them to me, along with your solutions and feedback, at *sandyasm@yahoo.com*. Till we meet again next month, happy programming, and here's wishing you the very best! END

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